

Lebanon

Ratio: 2:3 **Adopted:** December 7, 1943 **Usage:** National

*The white band
symbolizes peace*



*The cedar tree
represents holiness,
eternity, and strength*

*The two red stripes are
a symbol of self-sacrifice*

Asia



Lebanon became independent in 1944, after 20 years as a French mandate. The country is currently rebuilding after 14 years of civil war.

The present Lebanese flag was adopted just prior to independence from France, in 1943. It was designed to be a neutral flag, not allied to any one of Lebanon's religious groups. Red is thought to be for the color of the uniforms worn by the Lebanese Legion during World War I. Officially the red is said to represent the people of Lebanon's sacrifice during the struggle for independence, and white represents purity.

THE CEDAR OF LEBANON

Although the flag has only existed for half a century, the tree at the center of the flag—the Cedar of Lebanon—has been an emblem

of the country since the time of King Solomon, almost 3000 years ago. Specifically, the cedar is the symbol of the country's Maronite Christian community. It first appeared on a flag in 1861 when the Lebanon was part of the Ottoman Empire. Soon after its collapse, the country became mandated to France and its flag was a French *Tricolore*, with the Cedar of Lebanon in the white band of the *Tricolore*. The cedar symbolizes happiness and prosperity for the country.

The present flag, with the cedar's foliage and trunk in green, has a variant in which the tree trunk is brown—although this is not officially recognized.